

ART & CULTURE



RELIGION AND PHILOSOPHY

MODULE - 6

BUDDHISM- ITS DECLINE AND INFLUENCE ON CULTURE

CAUSES FOR THE DECLINE OF BUDDHISM

1

In the beginning Buddhism like every religion is inspired by the spirit of reform.



2

But eventually it succumbed to rituals and ceremonies it originally denounced.

3

Buddhism faced a deterioration of its norms.

4

It became a victim to the evils of Brahmanism against which it had fought in the beginning.

5

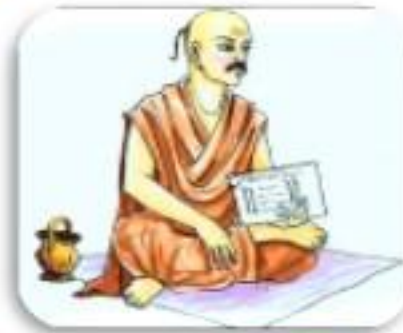
To meet the Buddhist challenge the brahmanas reformed their religion.

6

They stressed the need for preserving the cattle wealth and assured women and shudras of admission to heaven.

7

Buddhism, on the other hand, changed for the worse.



CAUSES FOR THE DECLINE OF BUDDHISM



8 Gradually the Buddhist monks were cut off from the mainstream of people's life; they **gave up Pali**, the language of the people, and took to Sanskrit, the language of intellectuals.

9 From the 1st century A.D. onwards, they **practised idol worship** on a large scale and **received numerous offerings** from devotees.

10 The rich offerings supplemented by generous royal grants to the Buddhist monasteries made the life of monks easy.

CAUSES FOR THE DECLINE OF BUDDHISM



The Buddha is reported to have said to his favourite disciple Ananda:

"If women were not admitted into the monasteries Buddhism would have continued for one thousand years, but because this admission had been granted it would last only 500 years".

11 By the 7th century A.D., the Buddhist monasteries had come to be dominated by **ease-loving people and became centres of corrupt practices** which Gautama Buddha had strictly prohibited.

12 The new form of Buddhism which took form was known as Vajrayana.

13 The **enormous wealth of the monasteries with women living in them** led to further degeneration.

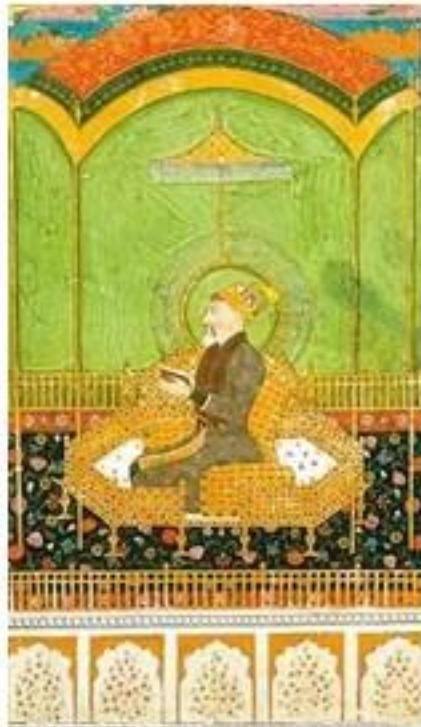
14 Buddhists came to look upon women as objects of lust.

CAUSES FOR THE DECLINE OF BUDDHISM

- 15** The brahmana ruler **Pushyamitra Shunga** is said to have persecuted the Buddhists.



*Persecution of Buddhists
by various rulers*



- 16** Several instances of persecution occurred in the 16th -17th centuries A.D.
- 17** The Huna king **Mihirakula**, who was a worshipper of Shiva, killed hundreds of Buddhists.
- 18** The **Shaivite Shashanka of Gauda** cut off the Bodhi tree at Bodh Gaya, where the Buddha had attained enlightenment.
- 19** Huan Tsang states that 1600 stupas and monasteries were destroyed, and thousands of monks and lay followers killed; this may not be without some truth.

CAUSES FOR THE DECLINE OF BUDDHISM

20 The Buddhist reaction can be seen in some pantheons in which **Buddhist deities trample Hindu deities**.

21 In South India, both the Shaivites and Vaishnavites bitterly opposed the Jainas and Buddhists in early medieval times.

22 Such conflicts may have weakened Buddhism.

23 For their riches the monasteries came to be coveted by the **Turkish invaders**.

24 They became special targets of the invaders' greed.

25 The Turks killed a large number of Buddhist monks in Bihar, although some of the monks managed to escape to Nepal and Tibet.

IMPORTANCE AND INFLUENCE OF BUDDHISM



1 Despite its ultimate disappearance as an organized religion, Buddhism left its abiding mark on the history of India.

2 The Buddhists showed a keen awareness of the problems that faced the people of north-east India in the sixth century B.C.

3 The new iron ploughshare agriculture, trade, and the use of coins enabled the traders and nobles to accumulate wealth, and we hear of people possessing eighty kotis of wealth.

4 All this naturally created sharp social and economic inequalities.

5 So Buddhism asked people not to accumulate wealth.

6 According to it poverty breeds hatred, cruelty and violence.

IMPORTANCE AND INFLUENCE OF BUDDHISM



- 7** To eradicate these evils the Buddha advised that farmers should be provided with grain and other facilities, the traders with wealth, and the labourers with wages.

- 8** These measures were recommended to remove poverty in this world.

- 9** The code of conduct prescribed for the monks represents a reaction against the material conditions of north-east India in the sixth and fifth centuries B.C.

- 10** It imposes restrictions on the food, dress and sexual behaviour of the monks.

IMPORTANCE AND INFLUENCE OF BUDDHISM



11 They cannot accept gold and silver and they cannot take to sale and purchase.

12 These rules were relaxed after the death of the Buddha but the early rules suggest a **return to a kind of primitive communism**.

13 The code of conduct prescribed for monks partially reflect a revolt **against the use of money, private property and luxurious living**, which appeared in the 6th century B.C. in north-east India.

14 In those days property and money were regarded as luxuries.

IMPORTANCE AND INFLUENCE OF BUDDHISM



15 Although Buddhism tried to mitigate the evils resulting from the new material life in the 6th B.C. , it also tried to consolidate the changes in the social and economic life of the people.

16 The rule that debtors were not permitted to be members of the sangha naturally helped the moneylenders and richer sections of society from whose clutches the debtors could not be saved.

17 Similarly the rule that slaves could not join the sangha helped the slave owners.

18 Thus the rules and teachings of Gautama Buddha took full account of the new changes in the material life and strengthened them ideologically.

IMPORTANCE AND INFLUENCE OF BUDDHISM

19 Although the Buddhist monks had renounced the world and repeatedly criticized the greedy brahmanas, in several ways they resembled the brahmanas.

20 Both of them did not participate directly in production, and lived on the alms or gifts given by society.

21 Both of them emphasized the virtues of carrying out family obligations, protecting private property and respecting political authority.

Undoubtedly the objective of the Buddhist teaching was to secure the salvation of the individual or nirvana.

BUDDHISM

IMPORTANCE AND INFLUENCE OF BUDDHISM

IMPACT ON WOMEN & SHUDRAS



22 Buddhism made an important impact on society by keeping its doors **open to women and shudras**.

23 Since both women and shudras were placed in the same category by Brahmanism, they were **neither given sacred thread nor allowed to read the Vedas**.

24 Their conversion to Buddhism freed them from such marks of inferiority.

IMPORTANCE AND INFLUENCE OF BUDDHISM

EMPHASIS ON NON-VIOLENCE



- 25** With its emphasis on non-violence and the sanctity of animal life, **Buddhism** **boosted the cattle wealth** of the country.

- 26** The earliest Buddhist text Sutta Nipata declares the cattle to be **givers of food, beauty and happiness** (annada, vannada, sukhada), and thus pleads for their protection.

- 27** This teaching came significantly at a time when the non-Aryans slaughtered animals for food, and the Aryans in the name of religion.

- 28** The Brahmanical insistence on the sacredness of the cow and non-violence was apparently derived from Buddhist teachings.

BUDDHISM

IMPORTANCE AND INFLUENCE OF BUDDHISM

PROMOTION OF RATIONALISM



DID YOU KNOW?

- In ancient Indian Buddhist monasteries, a ceremony called Pavarana used to be held.
- It was the confession by monks of their offences committed during their stay in the monasteries during the rainy season.

29 Buddhism created and developed a new awareness in the field of intellect and culture.

30 It taught the people not to take things for granted **but to argue and judge them on merits.**

31 To a certain extent the place of **superstition was taken by logic.**

32 This promoted **rationalism** among people.

IMPORTANCE AND INFLUENCE OF BUDDHISM

GROWTH OF PALI LITERATURE



- 33** In order to preach the doctrines of the new religion, the Buddhists compiled a new type of literature.

- 34** They enormously enriched Pali by their writings.

- 35** The early Pali Buddhist literature can be divided into 3 categories.
- The first contains the sayings and **teachings** of the Buddha.
 - The second deals with the **rules** to be observed by members of the sangha
 - The third presents the **philosophical exposition** of the dhamma.

BUDDHISM

IMPORTANCE AND INFLUENCE OF BUDDHISM

GROWTH OF PALI LITERATURE



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- 36** In the first three centuries of the Christian era, by mixing Pali with Sanskrit the Buddhists created a new language which is called **Hybrid Sanskrit**.

- 37** The literary activities of the Buddhist monks continued even in the Middle Ages, and some famous Apabhramsa writings in east India were composed by them.

- 38** The **Buddhist monasteries** developed as great centres of learning, and can be called residential universities.

- 39** Mention may be made of Nalanda and Vikramashila in Bihar, and Valabhi in Gujarat.

IMPORTANCE AND INFLUENCE OF BUDDHISM



40 Buddhism left its mark on the art of ancient India.

41 The first human statues worshipped in India were probably those of the Buddha.

42 The faithful devotees portrayed the various events in the life of the Buddha in stone.

43 The panels found at **Gaya in Bihar** and at **Sanchi and Bharhut in Madhya Pradesh** are illuminating examples of artistic activity.

44 From the first century A.D. onwards the panel images of Gautama Buddha began to be made.

IMPORTANCE AND INFLUENCE OF BUDDHISM



- 45** The Greek and the Indian sculptors worked together to create a new kind of art on the north-west frontier of India, which is known as the **Gandhara art**.
- 46** The images made in this region betray Indian as well as foreign influence.
- 47** For the residence of the monks rooms were hewn out of the rocks, and thus began the **cave architecture in the Barabar hills in Gaya and in western India around Nashik**.
- 48** Buddhist art flourished in the Krishna delta in the south and in Mathura in the north.

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